

VOCABULARY: SYNONYMS OF WORDS

A synonym is a word or phrase that means exactly or nearly the same as another word or phrase in the same language for example “shut” is a synonym for “close”. Synonyms are also words that have almost the same meaning; begin – commence, battle – conflict, tinge – stain, keen – sharp, acute etc. We should also know that no two English words are exactly identical in their meaning and usage, just as not two human faces are likely to be completely identical in their features. Some words may appear identical at first, a close examination will show differences in the usage. For example, “wealthy” and “rich” appear to mean the same thing. However, while “wealthy” is used in relation to money and property, “rich” has many other applications e.g. rich colour, rich cake, rich decoration, rich soil etc. Again while “fragrance” is used in reference to “perfume”, its synonyms “aroma” and “odour” show differences in usage. While “aroma” is used in relation to wine or spirits, “odours” often suggests a foul smell.

Some words share equivalence in meaning, precise equivalence may be interchangeable as in.

- a. He has a big house
- b. He has a large house

“Big” and “large” are interchanged here in terms of size. But in, that was a big help, “big” cannot be interchanged with “large” neither can “large” be interchanged with “big” in, He was in a large part responsible for what happened. There is no “absolute sameness” in synonyms.

It is a good test of discrimination to select or take the most appropriate word. Sometimes, one synonym is realized more than another; example: “Beautiful” has a deeper and more specific meaning than “pretty” or “a lovely”. Therefore, when we say that two words are synonyms we mean that they are similar in a specific context and can be used to replace each other in the context.

The importance of synonyms stems from the fact that it provides variety for words in English language. It helps one to know the exact words to be used in the prevailing context. Examples of words and their synonyms

Words

Synonyms

- | | |
|------------------|-------------------------------------|
| 1. Annihilation | Destruction, carnage, extinction |
| 2. Benefit | Profit, revenue, yield, gain |
| 3. Deterioration | Pollution, defilement, adulteration |
| 4. Enormous | Huge, gigantic, massive |
| 5. Fertile | Fruitful, abundant, productive |
| 6. House | Dwelling, abode, domicile |
| 7. Intelligent | Clever, brilliant, knowledgeable |

8. Loyal	Faithful, ardent, devoted
9. Organization	Institution, management
10. Partner	Associate, colleagues, companion
11. Polite	Cautious, cordial, gracious
12. Risky	Dangerous, perilous, treacherous
13. Sleepy	Drowsy, sluggish, listless
14. Vacant	Empty, deserted, uninhabited
15. Apex	Summit, climax
16. Protagonist	Hero, star, major actor

How to identify correct synonyms

1. The tense of the word used; Tense in English simply means or refers to the time of an action performed by the subject and indicated by the verb. We have the present tense, past tense and future tense e.g.
Begin – start
Began – started
Beginning – Starting
2. The part of speech which the word used belongs to; nouns, pronouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, prepositions, conjunctions and interjections.

Exercise

Provide the correct synonyms to these words

1. Deprived stripped
2. Career
3. Counterpart
4. Practice
5. Distinguishing
6. Heeding
7. Kinsmen
8. Odds
9. Roared
10. Monster
11. Inferno

References

Basic English Grammar for Schools and Colleges by Chidinma C. Nduaguibe

Complete English Course for Senior Secondary Schools by Ukamaka Chioma Ibe Ph.D

